

LiveTimer

Instructor Guide

What is LiveTimer?

LiveTimer is a real-time classroom timer for virtual and in-person instruction. You set timers for breaks, labs, and activities from your instructor control panel. Your students see the countdown on their phones or on a projected screen. The timer follows the student — they scan a QR code and the countdown is on their phone, so they can walk away from their desk and still know when to come back.

Getting Access

Your LiveTimer administrator will create an account for you and provide your login credentials (a Login ID and a temporary password). Once you have those, follow the steps below.

Logging In

- 1 Open your web browser and go to:

<https://livetimer-classroomtimer.onrender.com/instructor>
- 2 Enter the **Login ID** and **password** provided by your administrator.
- 3 Click **Login**. You will be taken to the instructor control panel.

***Tip:** After your first login, the browser remembers you — you won't need to log in again unless you clear your browser data or use a different browser.*

Changing Your Password

- 1 Click the **gear icon** in the top-right corner to open Settings.
- 2 Find the **Change Password** section. Enter your current password and your new password, then click **Change**.

The Instructor Panel

The instructor panel has two main areas side by side:

- **Left column** — A phone-shaped mockup that shows exactly what your students see. This is your live preview and your main editing surface.
- **Right column** — Tabs for **Timers** (your timer library and sequences), **Alarms** (time-of-day alerts), and **Students** (connections and check-in status).

Below the mockup you'll find an **Edit / Live** toggle. Edit mode lets you type directly on the mockup. Live mode shows an iframe of the actual student page — a pixel-perfect preview of what phones see, including check-in buttons.

Working with Timers

There are several ways to create and start a timer. The method you choose depends on how often you reuse the same timer settings.

Method 1: Quick Timer (Mockup)

The fastest way for a one-off timer. Type directly on the mockup:

- 1 Use the **hour/minute spinners** on either side of the clock digits to set the duration. Hold an arrow down to spin rapidly.
- 2 Click the **label** area below the clock to type a label (e.g., "Break").
- 3 Click **Play**. The timer starts on all connected phones immediately.

This works well for spontaneous timers, but for timers you use repeatedly, the library is more efficient.

Method 2: Timer Library (Recommended)

The **Timers** tab contains your saved timer presets — a collection of pre-configured timers you can start with one click. This is the recommended way to work with timers because it's fast and consistent.

- **Click a timer name** to load its settings onto the mockup (ready to review and start).
- **Click the play button** next to a timer to load AND start it immediately in one click.
- Create new library timers using the toolbar buttons (page icon for dialog, page-with-plus for inline).

Method 3: Duration Popup

Click the **clock icon** on the mockup (below the left spinner) to open the Duration Popup. This gives you:

- Larger hour/minute spinners
- **Quick-set buttons** for common durations (5, 10, 15, 30 minutes, etc.)
- **Target Time mode** — set an end time (e.g., "10:30 AM") and the duration is calculated automatically

Method 4: Sequences

Sequences let you chain multiple library timers together so they run one after another automatically. At the top of the Timers tab, toggle between **Timers** and **Sequences** views. Create a sequence by adding timers from your library in order, name it, and save. Click a sequence name to start — the first timer plays, and when it finishes, the next one loads automatically. A progress bar shows the current and next steps, with Skip and End buttons for manual control.

Transport Controls

Below the phone mockup, you'll find four transport buttons:

- **Play** — Start the timer. All connected students see the countdown begin.
- **Pause** — Freeze the countdown. Students see it paused.
- **Stop** — End the timer completely. The clock resets to 00:00 and all text fields (except Course Title) are cleared. The alarm sound stops.
- **Restore** — After stopping, brings back the last timer with recalculated remaining time. Useful if you accidentally stop a running timer.

Stop vs. Restore: *Stop is final — it zeroes the clock. But if you stopped by mistake, Restore recovers the timer and recalculates how much time was left based on the original end time. It's like an undo for Stop.*

Adding Time to a Running Timer

If a timer is running and you need to give students more time:

- 1 Click the **clock icon** on the mockup to open the Duration Popup. The popup opens even while the timer is running.
- 2 Set the amount of time you want to add using the spinners or quick-set buttons.
- 3 Click the **+Add** button. The extra time is added to the running timer immediately. Students see the countdown jump.

Note: *The +Add button adds time to the running timer. The Play button in the popup would replace the current timer with a new one.*

Push and Pull

When you edit text on the mockup, your changes are local until you send them to students. This is where **Push** and **Pull** come in.

Push

Sends the text from the mockup field to all connected students. When you click a field on the mockup and type, students don't see the change yet — you're editing your local copy. Click **Push** (or **Push All** below the mockup) to send it live. The Play button also pushes all fields automatically before starting.

Pull

Does the opposite — loads the current student-visible value back into the mockup field. Use this when you want to see what students are currently seeing, or to undo a local edit that you haven't pushed yet.

Each editable field has its own Push, Pull, Clear, and Revert buttons that appear when you click on the field. There's also a **Push All** button below the mockup that pushes all fields at once.

When to use Push: *If you're preparing the next timer while the current one is running, you can type the new label and message without students seeing it. When the timer finishes and you're ready, Push All sends everything at once.*

Font Size Controls

Each text field on the mockup has small **A–** and **A+** buttons in its toolbar. These control the font size **on the student's phone**, not just on the mockup. Click A+ to increase the font, A– to decrease it. The display between them shows the current scale (e.g., "120%") or "auto" when no override is set. Click the percentage to reset to auto.

Font overrides are reset when you click Stop, so each timer starts fresh.

Sharing the Timer with Students

Students connect by scanning a QR code or entering a 4-character class code on their phones.

- 1 Click the **Students** tab. You'll see your **class code** and a **QR code**.
- 2 Display the QR code on your projector, share your screen in Zoom, or use the dedicated QR display page for OBS.
- 3 Students scan the QR code with their phone camera. The timer opens in their browser — no app install needed. Alternatively, they can go to the LiveTimer URL and enter the 4-character code.

Each instructor has their own class code. Your students only see your timer.

Student Monitoring

The Students tab shows how many phones are connected and lists each student by name. Enable **Check-in buttons** to let students report their status (Working, Done, Away). You'll see a real-time summary with color-coded counts. Enable **Class progress on phones** to let students tap the progress ring on their phone to see an anonymous breakdown of class status (proportional donut chart — no names or numbers, just proportions).

Disconnect All Phones generates a new class code and disconnects everyone. Students need to re-scan or re-enter the new code. Use this between classes.

Settings

Click the **gear icon** in the top-right corner to open Settings. Here's what you'll find:

Change Password

Enter your current and new password to change your login credentials.

Instructor Phone

Scan the QR code or copy the URL to connect your own phone to the timer without being counted as a student. Useful for monitoring the timer from your phone while teaching.

Color Palette

Choose from 13 color themes across four categories: Dark, Medium, Light, and Loud. Your choice is saved automatically. The palette only affects your instructor view — students always see the standard dark theme.

Alarm Sound

Select the sound that plays when a timer finishes. You can choose from built-in sounds or upload a custom .mp3 file. Enable **Loop** to repeat the sound until you stop it.

Warning Alert

A separate sound that plays a configurable number of minutes before the timer ends (e.g., a gentle chime 5 minutes before the break is over). Enable it, choose a sound, and set the minutes.

After Starting

Choose which tab to switch to automatically after starting a timer (Timers, Students, or Settings).

Student Updates (Mute)

When muted, timer changes only appear on your instructor panel — not on student screens. Useful for testing or preparing without disrupting students.

Library Backup

Export saves your entire timer library as a JSON file. **Import** loads a previously exported library. Use this for backup or to transfer your timers to another instructor account.

OBS URLs

Pre-built URLs you can copy and paste into OBS Studio as browser sources:

- **Timer URL** — Shows the student countdown view. Use as a browser source in OBS to display the timer on your stream or projected screen.
- **Timer URL with ?obs=true** — Same as above but skips the code entry gate and identifies as a display viewer. Respects Transparent and Clock Only modes.
- **QR-Only URL** — A dedicated page showing only the QR code, class code, and connection instructions. Use as a browser source in an OBS scene where students need to connect.

***OBS Tip:** In each browser source's properties, enable "Refresh browser when scene becomes active" so the timer reloads after updates. Set dimensions to match your display size for crisp text.*

Display Modes

Each timer in the library can have display modes saved with it. These affect only projected screens and OBS sources — never student phones:

- **Show End Time** — Displays the clock time the timer will end (e.g., "Back at 10:45 AM"). Helpful for breaks.
- **Clock Only** — Hides everything except the countdown digits on displays. Phones still show the full view.
- **Transparent** — Makes the background transparent on displays, useful for overlaying the timer on slides or camera feeds in OBS.
- **Black Background** — Solid black background on displays.

Clock Only and Transparent can be combined for a minimal, floating-digits overlay.

Alarms

Alarms are time-of-day alerts that fire at a specific clock time (e.g., 10:30 AM). Unlike timers, which count down a duration, alarms trigger at an absolute time. They're for class start/end times, mandatory breaks, or any schedule-driven event.

Each alarm has: a name, a time (with AM/PM), a sound, optional visual flash, optional repeat, and day-of-week scheduling (S M T W T F S buttons — toggle days off for classes that don't meet every day). A **master toggle** at the top turns all alarms on or off at once.

Alarm Sets let you maintain separate groups of alarms for different classes or schedules. Switch between sets using the dropdown. Create, duplicate, rename, or delete sets as needed.

Need Help?

Click the **?** button in the top bar of the instructor panel to open the built-in help guide. It covers every feature in detail and can be printed.

First-time tip: *The server runs on a free hosting tier. If the page takes a few seconds to load on your first visit, that's normal — the server is waking up. Once active, everything runs in real time.*